PRAMANAS OF ASTHIKA DARSANA
A STUDY

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CHAPTER - 6

FINDINGS AND CONCLUSION

6.0 Findings

Indian philosophy developed through centuries of tradition consisting of Āstika and Nāstika darśanas which could be a challenge to even the scientific and empirical attitude of the present day world. Indian approach towards philosophy has been interpretative as well as creative. Saṅkara, for instance, was a commentator on the Brahma Sūtras, but he is regarded as one of the most original thinkers of the world.

While scholars have evaluated British philosophy as empirical, American philosophy as realistic, French philosophy as rationalistic, and German philosophy as speculative, Indian philosophy is universally accepted as meditative. It is observed to be spiritual because its emphasis is on other worldly values.

Philosophy is termed Darśana in India because it is believed that it is capable of giving a vision of reality. The ancient darśanas of India tell us that human suffering is on account of our ignorance regarding the nature of the real. One who cannot make a distinction between the real and the unreal wrongly develops an attachment for the unreal and the transient, which may bring suffering.

Hence Indian philosophy or Darśana appears to be a way of looking at things. Philosophical knowledge creates in one an awareness of different perspectives towards life.

The term used to denote real knowledge is Prāma. Pramāṇam is the means used to acquire Prāma related to Prameya viṣaya or subject by Prāmatav (ātma) who is the seeker of knowledge. Pramāṇam is the Karaṇam of Prāma. Prāma or knowledge has two functions – Prāma janakatva (the creation of knowledge), and Prāma jñapakatva (to find out whether the knowledge is true or false). Pramāṇa is defined as "anādhigatharthaganthya" (or to know what is not known before) by the Mīmāmsakas.

For Pratyakṣa jñana the contact between object and sense organ is necessary. Like that the union between sense and mind, and also between mind and ātma are also required.

"Indriya mana samyoga" and " ātma mana samyoga." Darśanam is the "sādhaka thama karaṇam" of knowing the existence of an object. Since "ātmamansamyoga" is required for all knowledge, only viṣeyandriya. Samyoga is considered that basis of Pratyakṣa jñana. Therefore pratyakṣa Pramāṇa is called "indriyartha sannikarsa janyam."[1] The Naiyayikas accept only four Pramāṇas, which are Pratyakṣam, anumānam, Upamāna and Śabdam. The number of Pramāṇas accepted by other Upamāna vary

from one to six. For eg. the Cārvākas accept only Pratyakṣam, the Vaiśeṣika only two (Pratyakṣam and anumānam), and Saṅkhya – yoga systems three Pramāṇas (Pratyakṣam, anumānam and Śabdam). The Mīmāmsa and Vedānta Darśana accept six Pramāṇas including arthapatti and Anupalabdhi. However different schools like those of Kumārila Bhaṭṭa and Prabhakara Miśra differ in their view points regarding the last two Pramāṇas.

Pathyakṣam, which is the most important Pramāṇa of all Darśanas is defined as

"prathyaksa jñana karanam prathyaksam. It is the knowledge that is born out of the communion between sense and object. It is of two kinds, namely Nirvikalpa and Savikalpa. Nirvikalpa jñana has no prakarabodha, whereas Savikalpa has Prakarabodha. The word Pratyakṣa is used to denote both the knowledge acquired as well as the means adopted to receive it. In the above apta vakya the first prathyakṣam is the knowledge and the second word Pratyakṣam denotes the means to it.

Indriyartha means the which is cognized through the senses. For instance rupam or size is nayanendriartha and Śabda or sound is sravaṇendriyartha. When ātma joins the manas (mind), and manas joins the indriyas, and indriyas join the external objects or its meanings, viṣaya

jñana or knowledge of the subject occurs. Thus Pratyakṣa jñana is said to be indriyartha sannikarsa janya.

The Pratyakṣa jñana is eternal and hence not related to the contact of the sense object. It is due to jñana karana, which requires pūrva jñana. For instance Pramāṇas like anumāna needs pūrva jñana. Savikalpa Pratyakṣa also required pūrva jñana.

Nityam (eternal) means belongs to God. Anityam is 'man made', or 'belonging to man'. Pratyakṣa jñanam can be nityam or anityam. Laukikam can be related to the five senses and the sixth one, which is the manas or mind. Alankika Pratyakṣa jñanam can be either Samana lakṣaṇa, Jñana lakṣaṇa or Yoga lakṣaṇa.

The Buddist dārśanikas accept only nirvikalpa jñanam (immediate or direct sensory cognition), as Pratyakṣa Pramāṇa. They consider savikalpa as combined with pūrvajñana and anumāna. Anumānam is the karaṇam of Anumiti. It means the jñanam that it is achieved through paramarśa. The simple explanation of anumāna is that is a kind of guess on seeing an object, based on some previous knowledge related to it, resulting in the presence of some other knowledge. The new knowledge received is called anumiti.

To know the details of anumāna terms such as paksa, paksata, lingam, vyapyam, vyapakam etc. are to be understood. The object about which the new knowledge is guessed is called Paksam. The temporary peculiarity of the paksam is called paksata. The special feature of the paksa which causes the guess is termed lingam.

In the common example of smoke arising from faraway hill showing the presence of fire there, smoke is the lingam and fire is the liṅgi. Fire is also called vyapkam and smoke is here vyapyam. The knowledge that smoke is always present with fire is called sahacarya jñana. The resulting knowledge that there is fire on the hill is called Anumiti.

The concept of Anumāna can be compared to the syllogism of Aristotle. Both anumāna and sylogism are the same in effect. Comparatively Aristotlean syllogism seems simple than the anumāna of Naiyyāyikas.

Gautama divides anumāna into there categories such as pūrvavat, sesavat and samanya drta. The Karana of Upamithi is called Upamāna. Upamithi is the knowledge of the relation between an object and the name by which it is known Upamāna is accepted as a means to cognition by Nyaya and Mīmāmsa Upamāna, but Vaiśeṣika, Saṅkhya, yoga, Bouddha, Jaina and Cārvāka systems do not recognizse its.

Śabdam is called āpta vākya. Āpta is a person who seapks truth and is reliable. Śabda Pramāṇa is also not recognized by Vaiśeṣika, Jaina, Boudha and Cārvāka Upamāna. Saṅkhya, Yoga, Mīmāmsa and Vedānta accept only the vedās as Śabda Pramāṇa. Naiyayikas accept both the vedās and the words of a reliable person as Śabda. They divide Śabda into two categories – daivika and laukika. Vedic statements are daivika while apta vakya is laukika.

Jñana (knowledge) is considered the quality of ātma by Nyāya Darśana. Saṅkhya considers it as dravya. The Baṭṭa Mīmāmsakas look at Jñana as ātma dharma. To know is an activity or karma. The doer of this action is ātma. Kumarila Baṭṭa calls real knowledge as Pramāṇa and Prabhakara calls it "Samvith." There qualities required for real knowledge are dṛdatha (leak of doubt) 'novelty' or (no prior existence) avi samvaditvam (non-contrariness). Mīmāmsa holds the theory that every knowledge is considered as real knowledge, unless and until it is proved wrong by a contrary knowledge. On the other hand Bouddhas consider every knowledge as unreal till it is proved to be true.

To the Naiyyayikas Jñana is the guṇa of ātma. Saṅkhya darsanikas consider it as dṛvya. Both Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika consider smṛti and anubhava as Prāma or real knowledge. Mīmāmsaka who says that

knowledge should be new regard memory as not Prāma. Kumārila Bhaṭṭa defines Pramāṇa as:

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Pūrva Mīmāmsa acknowledges five Pramāṇas, which are Pratyakṣam, Anumānam, Śabdam, Upamāna and arthapatti. Mīmāmsakas also accept the Nyāya theory that ātma gets in touch with mind (manas), mind with senses (indriyas), and sense with objects. But they do not accept the explanations given by Naiyyayikas. Similarly Pratyakṣa jñana is of two kinds – Savikalpa and Nirvikalpa. The Nyāya theory discusses it is detail. However Mīmāmsakas have difference in their views and the views of Prabhakara and Kumārila Bhaṭṭa are different. Jaiminiṛshi has not included Śabdam as a Pramāṇa, but Dr. Radhakrishnan's opinion is different.[3]

Sabaraswami defines anumāna as

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It means anumāna is to grasp the presence of another object, knowing the relation between two objects, and seeing the one among them. Here also Kumarila and Prabhakara explain the definition in two different ways. Naiyyayika works at veda as the word of God but Vaiśeṣika regards Śabda as the word of a reliable person only. Mīmāmsaka does not believe in a personal God and hence to him the veda is not the word of God.

Śabdajñana is of two kind:- Laukika (that which is given by a person) and apauruseya (which is the vedic statement) Early Vaiśeṣikas and Bouddhas do not accept Śabda as a Pramāṇa. Prabhakara gives Pramāṇa status only to the veda, and not to aptavākya, because human beings may commit errors. Upamāna is not acceptable to many dārsanikas as it contains elements of Śabda and anumāna in it.

Philosophy is the use of reason and argument to seek truth and the knowledge of reality. It looks in the nature of things existence. Perhaps the greatest merit of Indian Darśanas is the willingness to listen to and understand what the others say. Indian Darśanas have never been hostile to other religions and philosophies of the world. One reason for the openness of the Indian view is the diversity of its cultural background, which has deep roots in the view that the path to Reality is not one, but many.

In the history of Western philosophy we find one school of thought predominating over others during a period, but another way of thought replacing it at some other period in a different situation. In India the system of thought becomes a way of life for a group of people. Different schools of thought existed side by side for centuries. Among them there were systems that accepted the authority of the vedās, and some which did not recognize either the authority of the scriptures or the existence of God. However all the systems of thought accepted the basic concept of the requirement of some means of knowledge of Pramāṇa.

The different philosophical Darśanas followed different way of lives. Different schools of philosophy from the materialism of Cārvāka, to the spirituality of Advaitha followed different methods of enquiry to realise the Reality. Pramāṇas are instruments of which knowledge can be materialised. The Āstika Darśanas recognize the Pramāṇas as sources of knowledge, but their number varies according to the schools from three to six. Like the western philosophical systems they are not intellectual efforts to enquire into Reality. Instead, the Pramāṇas of the Indian Darśanas aim at its realisation. For the intuitive realisation of truth intellectual brilliance is not enough. It should be tempered with spiritual advancement. The sages of India have only intellectually explained what they have experienced

intuitively. It is said that eating a badly cooked dinner is better than reading the best cooking book written by a famous cook.

The ideal aimed at by the Āstika Darśanas of India is the existence of a well ordered society based on spiritual values. The philosophy of each country has its own characteristics. For instance, British philosophy analyses, American philosophy tries to teach, French philosophy looks rationally, and German philosophy is thoughtful. In that respect, Indian philosophy appears to be meditative, and spiritual. It is called Darśana because it tries to give a vision of reality. It is believed that suffering is due to our ignorance regarding the real and the unreal. We develop an attachment for the unreal because we cannot make a distinction between the real and the unreal. Valid knowledge or Prama is that knowledge which makes us capable of this difference. Pramāṇas are the means by which true knowledge can be acquired. Hence the study of the Pramāṇas is always relevant to all.

Philosophy is a way of looking at life, philosophical knowledge helps us to create an attitude of difference in our perspective toward life. Though there were many schools of thought in India which had different views on God and life each school was ready to listen to what the other Darśana said, all the different Darśanas could exist and tolerate each other. The six Āstika Darśanas are called orthodox (Āstika) not because

they believe in God, but because they recognize the authority of the Vedās. For instance, the Mīmāmsa and the Saṅkhya Darśana do not believe in God as the creator of the world. The vedic tradition had two sides – the ritualistic and the speculative. (karma and Jñana). The Mīmāmsa school emphasized the aspect of ritualism while the Vedānta school emphasized the speculative aspect. So they are called Pūrva – Mīmāmsa (Karma Mīmāmsa) and Uttara – Mīmāmsa (Jñana – Mīmāmsa).

As per the Tarkasangraha, Tarkabhāsya and Yatpariya Ṭika knowledge or cognition (Jñana) or buddhi) is the manifestation of objects. Knowledge is of two kinds – anubhava or cognition and smrti or memory. Both can be either valid (yathartha) or non-valid (ayathartha). Prāma is the term used to denote valid cognition.[5] The means to obtain Prāma are called Pramāṇas, which are four according to Nyaya Darśana such as Pratyakṣa (perception) (anumāna) (inference), Upamāna (comparison) and Śabda or agama (verbal testimony). Non-valid congnition is termed a Prāma, which is divided into samsaya (doubt), bhrama or viparyaya (error) and tarka (hypothetical argument). [6]

Pratyakṣa (perception) is defined as "a definite cognition produced by sense – object contact, and is true and unerring."[7] There are laukika (ordinary) perception, and alaukika or extraordinary perception and bāhya

(external) and manasa (internal) perception. There are six kinds of laukika perceptions and three kinds of alaukika perceptions.

Anumāna (inference) literally means cognition which follows some knowledge. It is a process of ascertaining, not by perception or direct observation, but through the instrumentality or medium of a mark, that a thing possesses a certain character

Upamāna (comparison) is the third source of valid knowledge (Prāma) is Upamāna (comparison). It shows the relation between a name and things named or between a word and its denotation (sanjna sanjai sambandha). 'Upamāna is a process by which one recognizes some object, based on the description given by some body who is familiar with it.[8] For example, one who has not seen a wolf is told by a forester that it is like a big dog. When later he sees a wolf in the forest, he understands that it is a wolf, based on his knowledge of the appearance of the dog. The basis of our knowledge in Upamāna is the given description of an object known, and the perception of their similarity. [9]

Śabda (Agama) or testimony is the fourth of the Pramāṇas. Literally Śabda means verbal knowledge. It is the knowledge of objects derived from words or sentences. All verbal knowledge is not Śabda. Only the assertion of a trust worthy person is considered Śabda or source of valid knowledge.[10] (Nyayastra. 1.1.7)

The basic text of Nyaya – Darśana is the Nyaya – Sūtras of Gautama. Other texts that explain the Sūtrass of Nyaya – Sūtras are Vatsyayana's Nyayabhāsya, Udyotakara's Nyaya – Varthika and Vacaspati's Nyaya – Varthika Tatparya – Ṭika. Pramāṇa is the first among the sixteen padarthas discussed elaborately in the Nyāya philosophy. Pramāṇa is the means to grasp true knowledge. It includes various means to knowledge like Pratyakṣa, Anumāna, Upamāna, and Śabda (Agama) as Nyaya – Sūtras explains.

A verbal statement is valid when it comes from a person who knows the truth and speaks the truth about anything for the guidance of other persons.[11] Therefore Śabda (Agama) or testimony, as a source of valid knowledge, consists in understanding the meaning of the statement of a trust worthy person.[12]

Śabda or verbal testimony is classified into two – dṛstartha and adrstartha. The testimony relating to perceptible objects is dristartha and relating to objects that are imperceptible is called atrstartha.[13] There are also scriptural (vaidika) and secular (laukika) Śabdas (testimony)[14] In Nyāya philosophy Pramāṇas, as means of knowledge have direct relation with orameya or objects of knowledge. According to the Nyaya – Sūtras of Gautama all the prameyas or knowable objects are not to be found in the

physical world. For example, the self the mind (manas), pravṛtti, doṣa, (imperfections) dukha (suffering) feelings etc are not physical objects.

The Nyāya theory of the physical world is the same as that of the Vaiśeṣika, which is a samana tantra or allied theory.

The founder of Vaiśeṣika Darśana is sage Kanada, who wrote Vaiśeṣika – Sūtras. This treatise is divided into ten books, or adhyayas, each having two sections or ahnikas. Prasasthapada wrote the famous bhāsya of Vaiśeṣikam called Padarthadharma – Sangraha. The three well known commentaries of Prasasthapada's work are vyomasiva's vyomavati, udayana's kiranavali and Sridhaara's Nyaya – Kandali.

Both the Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika Darśana have the same objective of liberation of the self, and both consider that ignorance is the root – cause of all pain and suffering. Liberation is to be attained through the right knowledge of reality. On two fundamental points the two systems take different views. The first difference is that while Nyāya accepts the four Pramāṇa's (perception, inference, comparison and testimony), the Vaiśeṣika recognizes only two, namely, perception and inference. The other two are considered as parts of perception and inference respectively. The second difference is that the Nyāya darsanikas give a list of sixteen padārthas which constitute the whole of reality. The Vaiśeṣika, on the other hand believe that there are only seven padārthas. The word

padārtha refers to all objects of knowledge. They are divided into two classes called bhāva (being) and Abhāva (non-being). It is believed that there are six kinds of being (positive realities) and a seventh Padārtha called abhāva (negative facts).[15]

According to Nyāya – Vaiśeṣika Darśana the universal is the basis of sameness of a certain class. It is because there is a common essence in different individuals sāmanya or the universal is real entity corresponding to a general idea or idea of class in our minds. There is the same universal in all the individuals of a class. Vaiśeṣika – Sūtras's commentaries have included Abhāva (non-existence) as the seventh padartha.[16] Abhava (non-existence is of two kinds, namely, Samsargabhava and anyonyabhava. Samsargabhava is the absence of something in something else. Anyonyabhava is the fact that one thing is not another thing.

Like the Nyāya Darśana, the Vaiśeṣika is also a philosophy of realism which combines theism and pluralism. It believes that the different objects of the world are due to the combination of atoms, time and space, which are eternal, and it has reference to the moral life of individuals.

The contribution of Vaiśeṣika philosophy to the world of knowledge is its comprehensive conception of padārtha or object as that which is denoted by a word. It recognized the distinction between positive and

negative objects. The Vaiśeṣika's division of objects into seven classes and many sub-classes is logical and based on their characters and differences, moreover, the atomic theory of Vaiśeṣika is highly advanced when compared to the view of the world shared by other Darśanas. The advantage of the Vaiśeṣika is that it could harmonize the atomic theory of matter with the moral and spiritual outlook of life and the belief in God as the creator and moral controller of the world.

The system called Saṅkhya Darśanam was founded by sage Kapila out of the principles found in Smṛtis, Sūtras and puranas of ancient India. Kapila is the author of Saṅkhya – Sūtras and Saṅkhya – Pravacanba – Sūtras. The next authoritative text on Saṅkhya is Īśvarakrsna's Saṅkhya – Karika. Other commentaries on Saṅkhya – Sūtras are Gaudapada's Saṅkhya – Karika – bhāsya, Vacaspati's Tattva Kaumudi. Vijñanabhiksu's Saṅkhya – pravacana – bhāsya and Saṅkhya – sara, and Aniruddha's Saṅkhya pravacaba – Sūtras – vṛtti.

The Saṅkhya Darśana also aims at the knowledge of reality with the intention of finding an end to the pain and suffering in the world. It offers metaphysical knowledge of the self. While the Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika recognize the ultimate reality in atoms, minds and souls, the Saṅkhya admits only two kinds of ultimate reality – in the form of Puruṣa and Prakṛti (spirit and matter). The Saṅkhya system accepts only three sources of

knowledge (Pramāṇas), such as perception, inference and testimony of the scriptures. Other Pramāṇas like Upamāna (comparison), arthapathi (postulation), and anupalabdhi (non- cognition) are not considered independent sources. They are included under the three Pramāṇas.

There are three factors in all valid knowledge, which are Prāmata (the subject), Prameya (the object) and the source of knowledge (Pramāṇa). Prāma or valid knowledge is the reflection of the self in the intellect as modified into the form of the object. It is because the unconscious intellect can not cognize anything without the consciousness of the self.

Perception (Pratyakṣa) occurs due to the direct cognition of an object through its contact with some sense organs. There are two kinds of perception – nirvikalpa and davikalpa. The former is indeterminate and the latter is determinate perception. The nirvikalpa Pratyakṣa is also called alocana, in which cognition occurs by mere sensing of the object (eg: smell). We cannot communicate indeterminate perception to others using words. Savikalpa Pratyakṣa is cognition the result of analysis synthesis and interpretation so it is called vivecana or judgement of the mind.

In Inference the Saṅkhya system adopts the Nyāya view point in a slightly modified manner. There are two kinds of inference such as vita and avita. The former is affirmative inference and the latter is negative

inference. The vita is subdivided into pūrvavat and samanyatodrsta inference. Avita is what the Naiyayikas would call śeṣavat or pariśeṣa inference.[17]

Śabda (testimony) is made up of aptavacana or authoritative statement. It gives knowledge which cannot be acquired by perception or inference. A word works like a sign to denote something. Then it becomes a vacaka and its meaning (artha) is what is denoted by it, and it is called vacya. There are two kinds of Śabda ie. laukika and vaidika. laukika is the statement of ordinary, but trustworthy persons. The laukika Śabda is not regarded as a Pramāṇa by Saṅkhya Darśana. The vaidika Śabda consists to Sṛuti or the vedās, which is recognized as a third means of knowledge or Pramāṇa.

The Saṅkhya Darśanam is a philosophy of dualistic realism. This school of thought accepts the world as an interplay of Puruṣa and Prakṛti (spirit and primal matter). Prakṛti is regarded as the ultimate cause of the world of objects including physical things and products like the mind. Saṅkhya holds that be presence of Puruṣa or the self makes the Prakṛti to act. It is the effect of the conscious self on the unconscious intellect that makes the cognitive and psychical functions performed by Prakṛti .

The Yoga Darśana or philosophy of Yoga was codified by sage Patanjali, who authored the Yoga – Sūtras or Patanjala – Sūtras. Its

famous commentaries or bhāsya are Yoga – bhāsya by Vyasa, Vācaspati's Tattvavaisāradī. Bhoja raja's Vṛtti and Yoga maniprabha are also wellknown. Patanjali's Yoga – Sūtras has four parts, namely samādhipāda and Kaivalya pāda. The Yoga system is built on the strong foundation of Saṅkhya theory. All systems of philosophy in India have accepted the value of Yoga as an important method of attaining physical, mental and spiritual well – being. Even in the Upaniṣads there is clear evidence of the recognition of Yoga. In the Smṛtis and the Purāṇas also there is mention about Yoga.[18]

According to Yoga philosophy the cognitive mental states are different. They can be classified as five categories called Pramāṇa (true cognition), viparya (false cognition), vikalpa (verbal cognition) nidra (sleep) and smṛti (memory). There are three kinds of Pramāṇa (true cognition) such as perception (Pratyakṣa) inference (anumāna) and verbal testimony (Śabda).

The Yoga Darśana closely follows almost all the principles of Saṅkhya philosophy. For instance the three kinds of Pramāṇa are explained almost in the same manner as Saṅkhya does it.

Viparyaya is the wrong knowledge of objects including doubts and uncertain conditions. Vikalpa, on the other hand is mere verbal knowledge caused by words, but without no corresponding real facts. The phrase

"consciousness of the soul" arouses two different ideas such as soul and consciousness related together though in reality there is no distinction between them.[19] Yoga philosophy holds that all cognitive mental states and processes (citta – vṛtti) are included in the five cognitive functions of the mind.[20]

The principles of Yoga consider the self as a transcendent subject which is quite distinct from the self realisation has a strong basis in the Saṅkhya philosophy. It admits that there are deeper levels of consciousness than the empirical one. Western philosophers like Plato, Aristotle, Spinoza Leibniz, Kant and Hegal have also recognized glimpses of this deeper reality of our individual soul. What the Yoga does is to formulate some practical methods of purification and self control for the realisation of the true self of man.[21]

The Pūrva Mīmāmsa School (generally called the Mīmāmsa School) follows the ritualistic side of the vedās whereas the Uttara Mīmāmsa School (popularly known as the Vedānta School) follows the speculative side of it.

The theoretical basis of the Mīmāmsa is to be found in the twelve chapters of sage Jaimini's Mīmāmsa Sūtras. In this treatise justifying the authority of the Vedās, Jaimini discusses elaborately the nature of knowledge. He also explains the different sources of valid knowledge (the

Pramāṇas). The Mīmāmsa Darśana admits two kinds of knowledge such as immediate and mediate knowledge. Only that knowledge which gives some new information about something can be called valid knowledge. It should not be contradicted by any other knowledge. It should not be generated by some defective sense organ also. Moreover the object of immediate knowledge must be sat (some existing things).

When the object comes into contact with a sense, there arises an awareness of the object. This primary, indeterminate immediate knowledge is called Nirvikalpa Pratyakṣa or alochana – jñana. When we interpret the meaning of this object in the light of our past knowledge, it is called savikalpa perception.

In addition to Pratyakṣa (perception), Mīmāmsa acknowledges five other sources of knowledge, which are anumāna (inference), Upamāna (comparison) Śabda (authoritative testimony), arthapatti (postulation) and anupalabdi (non-perception). However, anupalabdi is not admitted by the school of Prabhakara. Only thee followers of the school of Kumārila Bhaṭṭa accepts anupalabdi as an independent Pramāṇa.

The philosophy of Mīmāmsa can be considers as ritualistic because it believes that the sole use of the vedās is in directing rituals. Being a pro-vedic school, the Mīmāmsa holds that though the Mīmāmsa does not

believe in God as the Creator or Destroyer, it considers the vedās as eternal.[22]

In addition to the authority of the vedās, the Mīmāmsa accepts as valid knowledge, the testimony of a reliable person (apta).[23] But the school of Prabhakara, like Vaiśeṣika holds that the non-vedic authority's testimony is based on inference.

Arthapatti (postulation) is the process of explaining something by affirming an explaining fact.[24] For example, when the primary meaning of a word is not suitable to the context, we postulate a secondary or figurative meaning to explain the statement. For instance, when we say the key is success is hard work, the meaning of the word 'Key' is figurative, and not literal.

Both Mīmāmsa and Advaita schools of thought accept Anupalabdi (non-perception) as a source of valid knowledge. They believe that non-perception of an object shows its non-existence.[25] There is visual perception when our eyes see an object in the light when we hear some body speaking meaningful there is testimony, when there is sufficient premises, there is inference. When the knowledge thus acquired leads to successful activity without contradiction, such knowledge is considered as valid. The knowledge can be invalid if the generation of the knowledge was defective due to the defective means of requiring knowledge.

Mīmāmsa holds that truth is self - evident. Valid knowledge assures us of its own true nature. Only objective conditions may produce false. Knowledge, which can be ascertained by inference. This view of Mīmāmsa is against the Nyāya view that every knowledge is ascertained by inference. If it is so inference will have to be verified by inference and so on.

The schools of Vedānta are built on the basis of the Upaniṣads. The Upaniṣads, the Bhagavat-Gita, and the Brahma – Sūtras of Bādarāyaṇa are known as the Prastāna traya or the triple foundation of the Vedānta. In the Sūtras Badarayana refers to about seven Achāryas of veda who were his predecessors. He also points out that there are differences in their views about mokṣa.[26] For instance, he refers to two views which are different from his own on the relation of Jīva to Brahma.[27] In short, there is wide ambiguity in some essential aspects of the veda. Therefore samskara is his great commentary (Brahma – Sūtras (Basya) upheld the view that the world is a phenomenal appearance of Brahma. Among the various schools of Vedānta only two - the Advaita school of Samskara and the Viśiṣtadvaita school of Ramanuja became prominent.

The most important feature of Advaita Vedānta is the conception of nirguna Brahma as the ultimate reality and the belief in the doctrine of the Maya. The concept of Mokṣa as the merging of the Jivātma (individual

soul) with Brahma (the cosmic soul) and Jñana as the means of liberation are the special features of this school of thought. Among the numerous works of Saṅkara, the most valuable is the Bhāsya of Vedānta – Sūtras (popularly known as Brahma – Sūtras). Besides the famous Bhāsya on Vedānta – Sūtras Sankara has authored commentaries on the major Upaniṣads and Sūtras – Bhāsya.

According to Saṅkara's Vedānta philosophy all knowledge points to an object as it does to a subject and there is no knowledge that does not involve this double features. Vedānta Sūtras states that if there is no object there can be no knowledge.[28] Hence Vedānta accepts the Pramāṇa arthapatti also. Arthapatti (postulation) is the supposition of an unperceived that demands explanation.[29] Like that, when the primary meaning of a word is not suitable to the context, we substitute a secondary or figurative meaning to explain the meaning. Advaita assumes that there is an object even in the so called Maya or illusion. The distinction between illusion and ordinary knowledge is not due to the absence and presence of an object, but to the difference in the character of the object pointed to them. Another difference between illusion and real knowledge is that illusion is short duration, while that a real knowledge is long lasting.[30] In the light of this distinction Vedānta says that error arises when different types of thins are related in a judgement.[31]

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Avidyā is directly the cause of illusion, but all knowledge has by hypothesis an object.

The Advaita vedānta recognize all the six Pramāṇas mentioned by the Kumarila school of Mīmāmsa. There are only some differences between the Mīmāmsa and Vedānta school about the Pramāṇas. For instance there is an element of difference regarding the Śabda or testimony Pramāṇa. The Mīmāmsa rejects the view that the vedās were composed by any body, while the Nyaya and Vaiśeṣika attribute the authorship to Īśvara. Like other vedantins Sankara adopts a mid-way view. He admits that the veda is apauruseya or authorless, but holds that it is eternal and is recreated at the beginning of each Kalpa. [32]

Like Kumarila, Sankara also admits that Śabda is a Pramāṇa outside the veda. So statements like Tattvam asi which is in the Upaniṣads are given logical value. The primary aim of the Pramāṇas, like perception is to serve empirical purposes. Sankara hols that the transcendental ideality of the world does not exclude its empirical reality.[33] Negative statements in the Upaniṣads like neti, neti (not this) are given only a secondary place in the Advaita. The primary importance is given to statements like Tattvam asi. In short, negation is only preliminary step

towards affirmation.[33] As Īsovāsya Upaniṣad says who sees all beings in himself and himself in all beings will dislike none.[34]

The Saṅkhya theory states that Prakṛti (unconscious primal matter) is composed of three guṇas such as sattva, rajas and tamas. It gives rise to the world without the guidance of any conscious agent. Other systems reject that the puruṣa admitted by Saṅkhya is said to be inactive and therefore unable to make the evolution of the world. Similarly the Vaiśeṣika theory that the world is caused by the combination of atoms is also not accepted by others because the unconscious atom cannot make the world of thoughts, feelings and imagination. The vedānta philosophy rejects the views that atoms can receive conscious guidance from the souls. The Upaniṣads state that man has no existence without God. Both Saṅkara and Rāmānuja accept this Upaniṣadic view. However their interpretations of man's dependence on God are different.

There is similarity in Saṅkara's conception of God and that of the Western philosopher Spinoza. Both conceive God not as an object of worship endowed with the highest attributes, but as the Supreme Reality. Their views are not atheistic, but super theistic. Atheism believes only in this world; but theism believes in God and the world; Saṅkara and Spinoza believe only in God. Faith is the highest emotion towards God, according to Saṅkara.[35]

Consciousness of the self is limited by the conditions of the body. The senses and antaḥkaraṇa (the internal organ of knowledge) are the instruments through which cognition of objects takes place. This empirical knowledge is of two kinds – immediate and mediate. The immediate knowledge of external objects occurs when through the senses the antaḥkaraṇa receives knowledge of the object. In addition to this immediate knowledge (Pratyakṣa), the vedānta school admits five other kinds of knowledge, which are mediate. They are inference (anumāna), testimony (Śabda), comparison (Upamāna), pistulation (arthapatti), and non-cognition (anupalabdhi).

6.1 Conclusion

In the contemporary scenario of Christian theology in India the pramāṇas of Indian perspective have developed considerable influence. For instance Neo-vedantic Christology has been recognized as an important off shoot of Indian dialogical theology. It provides an ideological basis for harmonious acceptance of diverse philosophical views in religious matters. Neo Vedānta emphasizes the possibility of Hinduism and Christianity interacting with each other on spiritual matters inspite of their theological differences. Neo Vedānta offers the Indians scope for their culture of tolerance and harmony. It also can provide an ideological basis for peace, love and happiness among people. Theoretically the

new perspective tries to combine the principles of Advaita, Visistadvaita and dvaita systems of Darśanas.

In fact, plurality of perception and harmonious inclusiveness of difference evolved due to the pramāṇas of Āstika Darśanas has provided Indian Philosophy the energy to reflect the multifaceted quality of human knowledge and experience. The other countries of the world do not have any epistemological base like this.

The philosophy of pluralism and Inclusiveness puts forward dynamic interaction between different perspectives through which we can cultivate peace and harmony in society. Holy dogmas sacred to every faith have to be really inclusive and pluralistic so that the world might bring happiness to mankind.

In short, Āstika Darśanas of India, in their essence, contain an earnest attempt to realize the Absolute spirit, and transform human life in the light of this spiritual experience. It lays stress on the inner purify of human mind, universal benevolence, eternal quest for the Infinite, and complete transformation of the intellectual, emotional and spiritual life of man.

In the contemporary Indian theological context Plutralistic Inclusivism is a viable alternative for the multitude of religious pramāṇas.

Christian theologians use Biblical sources as pramāṇas to explicate the theory of inclusiveness. Attention is focused more on the relationship between different religious faiths and the diversity of the world's religious quest. A new paradigm is evolving in the theology of religions and as a part of it a re- formulation of the perspectives such as exclusivism, Inclusivism and pluralism is getting attention in Christian theology also.

The exclusive and fundamentalistic views of religions are not becoming relevant in the Indian Philosophical context where religious diversity is a reality leaving no room for mutual hatred and suspicion. The glory of Indian pramāṇas does not support secretarian superiority or parochial sentiments.

Pluralism and inclusivism in matters of the comprehension of dogmas stick on to the belief that that Almighty is at the centre. They accept the point of view that what we need today is dynamic interaction between different faiths through which we can contribute to each other. So it can be observed that the revelations of God, Atman, Budha, krsna, Mohammed etc. are to be made truly pluralistic by their observations contributing to each other. Pluralistic Inclusivism suggests the perspective to let universal salvation come through God in the universally conceived Atman or God.

Christian missionaries of the contemporary times like K.P. Aleaz have tried to reformulate their views by elaborating the contribution of Sankara's Advaita Vedānta and the pramāṇas of Indian Darśanas in the Christian context. He tried to explain the possibility of understands the Gospels as the Upādhi (denominator) of Brahman, the namarupa (name) of Brahman, and the Karyam (effect) of Brahman. He has also discovered the possibility of interpreting the function of Christ as the Sarvagatatvam (all pervasive), Jyothi (illuminative) and ekikrtha (unificative) of the Supreme Brahma.

The philosophy of pluralistic Inclusiveness points out that the need of the time, is dynamic interaction between different faiths through which we can contribute to each other. The beliefs of every conviction might become pluralistic by contributing to each other so that all faiths would become truly inclusive and the world more peaceful and harmonious.

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